

The empowering potential of intergroup leadership: How intergroup leadership predicts psychological empowerment through intergroup relational identification and resources

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Abstract

As work increasingly transcends organizational boundaries, employee psychological empowerment benefits from resources provided by others outside of the employee's own team, department, or organization. These intergroup collaborations, however, may be inhibited by social identity and social categorization processes, so that the empowerment potential of these relations remains largely untapped. In this study ($N = 213$), we demonstrate that intergroup leadership is linked to employee psychological empowerment via intergroup relational identification and access to resources. In this way, this study demonstrates the empowering potential of intergroup leadership and intergroup relational identification for employees who collaborate across group barriers. We finish this paper by discussing the main implications for both empowerment and intergroup leadership theory, suggesting fruitful avenues for future research and highlighting the practical value for those who are motivated to increase psychological empowerment among boundary-spanning employees.

1 | INTRODUCTION

Psychological empowerment is a key predictor of outcomes like organizational performance and employee well-being (Maynard, Gilson, & Mathieu, 2012; Seibert, Wang, & Courtright, 2011; Spreitzer, 2008), work-unit performance (Seibert, Silver, & Randolph, 2004), innovation (Spreitzer, 1995), job satisfaction (Liden, Wayne, & Sparrow, 2000), and organizational commitment (Avolio, Zhu, Koh, & Bhatia, 2004), as it capitalizes the full potential available in every employee. Whether or not employees feel psychologically empowered largely depends on their access to information, support, means, and opportunities to learn and grow, which are considered crucial for employee performance (Kanter, 1977; Spreitzer, 1996). In order to enhance employee psychological empowerment, empowerment research and practice have predominantly focused on the hierarchical

flow of those resources from manager to employee (Maynard et al., 2012; Seibert et al., 2011; Spreitzer, 2008). However, due to consistent advances in information and communication technology, employees increasingly collaborate with relevant others outside their own group (Mills & Ungson, 2003). These interpersonal collaborations potentially affect the level of employee psychological empowerment by providing access to resources essential for optimal performance. This suggests that psychological empowerment, in addition to coming from manager directly to employee, may also come via collaboration with others within and across the boundaries of their own group (cf. Richter, West, Van Dick, & Dawson, 2006).

Developing these collaborations, however, does not come naturally to all people. Research on social identity and self-categorization processes within organizations demonstrate that employees tend to classify themselves and others into different social categories

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(Ashforth & Mael, 1989); whenever employees experience social identity and social categorization processes, whether implicitly or explicitly, they potentially hinder effective interpersonal collaboration with others outside their own group (e.g., Hains, Hogg, & Duck, 1997). A long research tradition in line with social identity theory has repeatedly demonstrated that social categorization processes lead to behavior based on ingroup favoritism (Ashforth & Mael, 1989). In the context of the organization, this means that employees tend to favor their own group over other groups, prefer activities that are in line with the goals of their own group, and choose to collaborate with fellow group members over non-members. This potentially harms interpersonal collaboration; thereby dismissing valuable opportunities to obtain the resources controlled by those others (i.e., employees who belong to other groups, such as other teams, units, or departments) to potentially enhance levels of psychological empowerment.

In order to address this issue, scholars have repeatedly highlighted the merits of a superordinate identity—a sense of identity that includes one's own group (e.g., department) and other groups into an overarching identity (e.g., organizational identity; Albert & Whetten, 1985)—to overcome these social identity and social categorization processes and to stimulate collaboration with others outside one's own group. However, due to the robustness of these social identity and social categorization processes many employees tend to ignore such a superordinate identity and prefer to identify with their own group and favor interaction with fellow group members. In recognition of this issue, other researchers have argued for “dual identification,” identification with both the own group and the superordinate group (e.g., Richter et al., 2006). Whereas the advantage of such dual identification is that it does not motivate group members to reject the overarching identification because it is seen to deny the distinctiveness of the own group within that overarching identity, the real risk is that it invites what is called ingroup projection (Mummendey & Wenzel, 1999): projecting the own subgroup identity unto the overarching identity and as a result discriminating against other subgroups as less representative of the overarching identity than the own group.

In recognition of these problems associated with identification with the superordinate group (i.e., including with dual identification), Hogg, van Knippenberg, and Rast (2012) introduced an alternative to this focus on superordinate identification: intergroup relational identification. Intergroup relational identification reflects self-definition in terms of one's group membership that also incorporates the group's relationships with other (collaborating) groups as part of the group's identity (Hogg et al., 2012, p. 233). Intergroup relational identification thus is a form of identification with the own (sub)group (e.g., the team) rather than the superordinate group (e.g., the organization), but differs from group identification as it is typically understood in that it incorporates the relationship with one or more other groups as part of the self-definition (i.e., just as individual relational identity is different from personal identity; Brewer & Gardner, 1996; Hogg et al., 2012). By embracing collaboration with others outside one's own group as a part of the “own” identity, intergroup relational

identification both acknowledges the robustness yet sidesteps the main difficulties of social identity and social categorization processes that hinder effective intergroup collaboration.

Intergroup relational identification, according to Hogg and colleagues (2012), is heavily dependent on leadership. Group leaders play an essential role in the formation of intergroup relational identification by employees. Hogg et al. introduced the concept of intergroup leadership as a set of behaviors aimed at stimulating employees to embrace intergroup relational identification. Phrased differently, by engaging in intergroup leadership, managers stimulate employees to develop intergroup relational identification, which encourages collaboration with others outside their own group. Such collaboration would give access to resources (e.g., different sources of information, additional support) not available in their own group. Because these resources are central to the development of psychological empowerment, the main goal of this study is to test the intergroup leadership–psychological empowerment relationship to develop our understanding of the role of intergroup leadership in building empowerment for employees operating across group boundaries.

In the present study, we demonstrate that intergroup leadership and employee psychological empowerment are related through intergroup relational identification and access to resources such as information, means, support, and opportunities to learn and grow. This study advances our understanding of employee psychological empowerment within contemporary organizations by showing that managers are able to enhance psychological empowerment by influencing the social identity of their employees. In doing so, our study also contributes to intergroup leadership theory by linking the concepts of intergroup leadership and intergroup relational identification to psychological empowerment that drives a wide range of organizational and individual outcomes.

2 | THEORY AND HYPOTHESIS

Employee psychological empowerment—defined as “an employee's intrinsic task motivation reflecting a sense of control in relation to one's work and an active orientation to one's work role, that is manifested in four cognitions namely meaning, self-determination, competence, and impact” (Spreitzer, 1995, p. 1443; Thomas & Velthouse, 1990)—is an essential predictor of a wide variety of positive organizational and individual outcomes (Maynard et al., 2012; Seibert et al., 2011; Spreitzer, 2008). Because of these merits, scholars and practitioners have been motivated to identify key antecedents that advance the level of employee psychological empowerment. In this endeavor, the focus has been mainly on managerial actions and the hierarchical transfer of resources from manager to employee. This has been captured by the concept of empowering leadership (Arnold, Arad, Rhoades, & Drasgow, 2000), albeit with slightly varying labels such as leadership empowerment behavior (Ahearne, Matthieu, & Rapp, 2005), empowering leader behavior (Konczak, Stelly, & Trusty, 2000), and external team leader behavior

(Kirkman & Rosen, 1999). Empowering leadership focused mainly on the transfer of resources from manager to employee to increase psychological empowerment of the employee, whereas this is a natural and logical focus from the perspective of the task at hand within that group context, employees increasingly operate across group boundaries, while group leaders do not have the discretion to provide access to resources outside their own group.

Within contemporary more decentralized organizations, employees increasingly transcend traditional group and organizational boundaries and collaborate with whoever is relevant for their task at hand (Forrester, 2000; Gittell & Douglass, 2012; Grant & Parker, 2009). By doing so employees potentially tap into a huge stock of resources with empowerment potential, which are controlled by people other than their direct manager (Ancona & Caldwell, 1992; Cross & Cummings, 2004; Hargadon, 2002). This suggests that employees are able to enhance their psychological empowerment by starting effective collaborations with potential colleagues outside their own group. Whether or not this happens is very much an issue of social identity.

2.1 | Social identity and collaboration across group boundaries

Social identity partly provides an answer to the self-definition question of “who am I?” (Ashforth & Mael, 1989). According to social identity theory, people categorize themselves and others into groups to better understand the world (Tajfel & Turner, 1986). Social identity is that part of self-definition that derives from this self-categorization as a group member. In order to identify with a group someone needs to feel psychologically connected with the group, and hence, experience the successes and failures of the group as his or her own (Ashforth & Mael, 1989; van Knippenberg & Sleebos, 2006). This makes the social identity as experienced by employees a key predictor of the potential successes or failures of intergroup collaborations (Brewer & Brown, 1998; van Knippenberg & Hogg, 2003).

In the context of organizations, social identity and social categorization processes influence the effectiveness of interpersonal collaboration with others outside their own group. The most fundamental idea in this respect is that identification with the own group can bias group members to favor own group over other groups, and thus, to be less willing to trust, communicate with, and collaborate with members of other groups (e.g., Brewer & Brown, 1998). Earlier work, therefore, suggested that a shift (e.g., invited by leadership's emphasis on the superordinate group) from group identification to identification with the superordinate group would improve intergroup relations (for a review, see Gaertner, Dovidio, & Samuel, 2000). More recent work recognized that people are often unwilling to shift their identification from the own group to the superordinate group, however. The own group tends to invite the stronger identification than the superordinate group (van Knippenberg & van Schie, 2000; Riketta & van Dick, 2005) and external (e.g., leader) attempts to put the emphasis on the superordinate group are often

rejected as a threat to the own distinctive group identity (Hewstone & Brown, 1986; Hornsey & Hogg, 2000). This has resulted in the “dual identity” perspective, suggesting that intergroup relations benefit when group members are invited to identify with both the own group and the superordinate group (Gaertner et al., 1999; Hewstone & Brown, 1986; Hornsey & Hogg, 2000; Richter et al., 2006). As this perspective was developed, it became increasingly clear, however, that dual identity can be problematic in that it can reflect “ingroup projection”: perceiving (and identifying) with the superordinate group as a reflection of the own subgroup, which invites bias against other subgroups that are different from the own subgroup (Mummendey & Wenzel, 1999; Wenzel, Mummendey, Weber, & Waldzus, 2003). Thus, when self-definition revolves around membership in their own team or department more than around organizational membership (and it typically does; Riketta & van Dick, 2005; van Knippenberg & van Schie, 2000), both an emphasis on superordinate identity alone and an emphasis on dual identity may hinder effective collaborations as intergroup biases lead to a preference to interact with others within their own group and to pursue goals that favor their own group over other groups.

This tendency toward intergroup biases is a potential breeding ground for intergroup conflict and may thus harm collaboration with others outside of their own group (Hogg & Terry, 2000). From the perspective of access to resources outside the own group as important to psychological empowerment, this is problematic. As people outside one's own group tend to operate in different flows of resources, employees may overlook or be denied opportunities to get access to unique—that is, to them—information, knowledge, and skills (Reagans & McEvily, 2003) crucial for the development of psychological empowerment.

To stimulate effective collaborations by employees, leadership may play an essential role because group leaders (e.g., team managers) have a unique position within a group. They are usually part of the group, but due to their role, they are also in the position to interact and collaborate formally and as a result also informally with representatives of other groups (Richter et al., 2006). As managers represent and embody the group (Giessner, van Knippenberg, van Ginkel, & Sleebos, 2013), they are the logical actors within a group to shape group members' understanding of the group's identity. More precisely, they are the ones who should underline the importance of effective collaborations beyond the boundaries of one's own group, and stimulate employees to adopt a social identity that values both in-group and out-group collaboration.

As noted in the previous, social identity research has highlighted the importance of promoting a superordinate, overarching identity by management (van Knippenberg, van Knippenberg, De Cremer, & Hogg, 2004). Although superordinate identity, when embraced, may lead to enhanced collaboration with others who fall under the umbrella of this superordinate social identity, co-workers may often resist embracing superordinate identity. Superordinate identity may also have unintended negative effects as people interpret the superordinate identity in the image of their own group. The first negative effect has been documented in research on nested identities (e.g.,

team within organization). It documented how people often resist a superordinate identity because it is experienced as a threat to one's own group identity (e.g., Hornsey & Hogg, 2000). The second negative effect, which has been documented in research on in-group projection (Mummendey & Wenzel, 1999), is that it outlines how people may often perceive the superordinate identity as largely a reflection of their own group and respond negatively to other groups as less fitting with superordinate identity. This line of research shows that there is a growing awareness that focusing on superordinate identity is a sub-optimal approach to managing collaboration across group boundaries (Hogg et al., 2012).

2.2 | The empowering potential of intergroup leadership

In order to address the problem of operating successfully across group boundaries, and in recognition that this often cannot be achieved through an emphasis on superordinate (including dual) identity, Hogg and colleagues (2012) proposed the concept of intergroup leadership. Intergroup leadership takes shape by communicating the importance of intergroup collaboration and its value for one's own group, on the one hand, and by acting in ways that are in line with the communicated intergroup relational identity, on the other hand. Hogg and colleagues (2012) outlined how intergroup leadership stimulates the formation of intergroup relational identification, in which group identity is understood as being shaped and defined by the group's collaboration with out-group partners. In intergroup relational identity, the groups are not subsumed within an overarching superordinate identity; rather, in intergroup relational identity the *relationship* with other groups is part of group identity. As a result, employees tend to focus more on the merits of intergroup collaboration and less on the differences and competition between the groups.

In this way, intergroup leadership acknowledges the robustness of the social identity and social categorization processes while simultaneously sidestepping the main hiccups for intergroup collaboration (Rast, Hogg, & van Knippenberg, 2018). This makes the cultivation of intergroup relational identification through intergroup leadership more effective than the cultivation of superordinate identification when it comes to stimulating effective collaboration with others outside one's own group.

By embracing an intergroup relational identity, employees define themselves in terms of one's own group membership including the group's relationships with others as part of one's own identity. This leads to a more positive attitude toward those others outside one's own group (Hogg et al., 2012; Rast et al., 2018). Because intergroup relational identification does not challenge one's own group's identity—indeed, it is an understanding of group identity—and does not invite ingroup projection, this is more effective than a focus on superordinate identity in the stimulation of effective intergroup collaboration. So, intergroup leadership stimulates the

formation of intergroup relational identification, which is more effective than a focus on stimulating superordinate identification when it comes to improving collaboration with others outside the group.

We propose that stimulating intergroup relational identification is important to psychological empowerment, because intergroup relational identification stimulates group members to effectively reach beyond the own group boundaries to acquire resources that are important to a sense of empowerment. Because psychological empowerment depends on access to resources such as information, means, support, and opportunities to learn and grow (Kanter, 1977; Spreitzer, 1996), collaboration beyond the boundaries of one's own group provides access to resources located outside of one's own group (Burt, 2000; Oh, Labianca, & Chung, 2006). Exactly these resources enhance the level of psychological empowerment. For example, access to information controlled by others outside one's own group helps an employee to make better-informed judgments (e.g., Ashford, Blatt, & Vande Walle, 2003; Cross, Borgatti, & Parker, 2001), to make better sense of the environment, and to better understand the purpose of his or her own job (Bowen & Lawler, 1992; Conger & Kanungo, 1988). Furthermore, having alternative collaboration partners limits the dependency of the employee on others as he or she has different ways to gain access to essential resources. Moreover, having multiple options provides the employee with a sense of self-determination (Astley & Sachdeva, 1984). Support and opportunities to learn and grow also enhance feelings of self-efficacy that help employees to have impact at work (Ashford et al., 2003; Bowen & Lawler, 1992; Gist & Mitchell, 1992).

In sum, intergroup leadership takes shape by communicating the importance of intergroup collaboration and its value for one's own group, on the one hand, and by acting in ways that are in line with the communicated intergroup relational identity, on the other hand. Intergroup leadership stimulates the formation of intergroup relational identification, in which group identity is understood as being shaped and defined by the group's collaboration with out-group partners. By embracing an intergroup relational identity, employees define themselves in terms of one's own group membership including the group's relationships with others as part of one's own identity. This leads to a more positive attitude toward those others outside one's own group (Hogg et al., 2012; Rast et al., 2018). This benefits the access to resources outside one's own group and affects an employee's psychological empowerment (see Figure 1 for our research model). This leads to the following hypotheses:

Hypothesis 1. Intergroup leadership is positively related to psychological empowerment.

Hypothesis 2. The relationship between intergroup leadership and psychological empowerment is serially mediated by intergroup relational identification and resources.

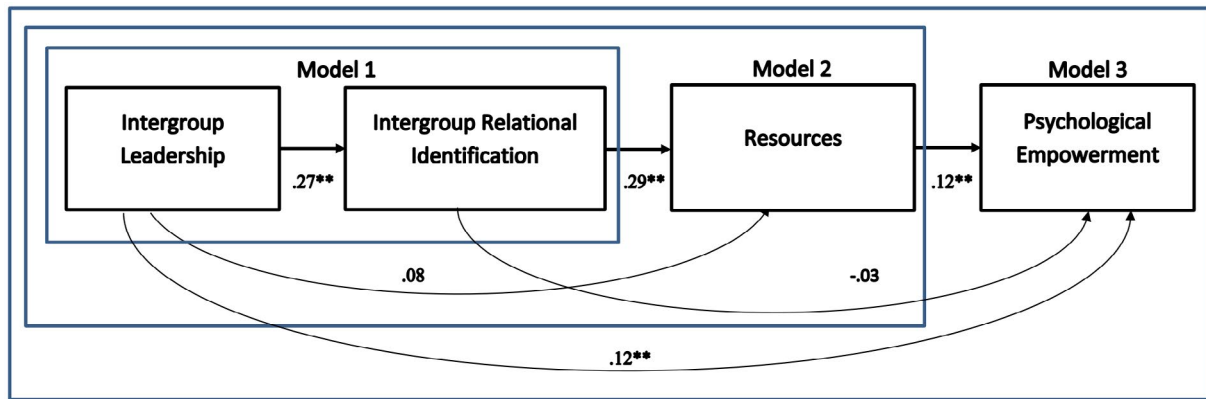


FIGURE 1 Research model [Color figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

3 | METHOD

3.1 | Procedure and participants

This study was part of a survey initiated by the Dutch Ministry of the Interior and Kingdom Relations. Respondents were drawn from a national panel of employees designed to be representative of employees of the National Government of the Netherlands. Respondents varied from police officers to elementary school teachers and from executive workers of the Ministry of Waterways and Public Works to magistrates. Of the 279 respondents who initially participated in this study, 213 respondents filled out the questionnaire completely (83%). Among these respondents 28% were female, their average age was 53.98 years ($SD = 7.88$ years), and most of them received higher education: 4% had a Ph.D., 30% had a university degree, 41% had finished higher vocational education, 21% had finished middle vocational education or pre-university education, and 4% had primary or secondary education.

3.2 | Measures

3.2.1 | Psychological empowerment

We measured psychological empowerment using the 12-item instrument by Spreitzer (1995) assessing the four main aspects of empowerment: *Meaning* (e.g., "The work I do is very important to me"); *competence* (e.g., "I am confident about my ability to do my job"); *self-determination* (e.g., "I have significantly autonomy in determining how I do my job"); and *impact* (e.g., "My impact on what happens in my department is high"). These items proved to be internally reliable (Cronbach's $\alpha = .84$).

3.2.2 | Intergroup leadership

We adapted Rast and colleagues' (2018) "leader rhetoric scale" to measure intergroup leadership. The nine items focused on communicating the importance of intergroup collaboration and its value for

one's own group (i.e., stimulation of an intergroup relational identity) and on acting in ways that are in line with the communicated intergroup relational identity (e.g., "My manager emphasizes that the collaboration with other departments shapes our identity"; "My manager makes clear that collaboration with other departments is crucial for 'who we are' as a department"). These items proved to be internally reliable (Cronbach's $\alpha = .94$) (see Appendix for the full scale).

3.2.3 | Intergroup relational identification

To measure intergroup relational identification, we again adapted items from Rast and colleagues (2018). The five items focused on the provision of self-definition in terms of the in-group's relationship with one or more relevant outgroups (e.g., "The relationship with other departments forms our identity"; "Who we are as our departments is defined by our relationship with other departments"). These items proved to be internally reliable (Cronbach's $\alpha = .90$) (see Appendix for the full scale).

3.2.4 | Resources

We measured the extent to which employees had access to resources needed for optimal performance at work from all other individuals (i.e., others within and outside their organization, friends, acquaintances, etc.) with four items. Based on research of Kanter (1977) and Seibert et al. (2011), we asked respondents specifically about information, instrumental means, social support, and opportunities to learn and grow, that is, "How much of the information you need to optimally carry out your work do you receive from people in your social network?"; "How much of the instrumental means you need to optimally carry out your work do you receive from people in your social network?"; "How much of the social support you need to optimally carry out your work do you receive from people in your social network?"; and "How much of the opportunities to learn and grow you need to optimally carry out your work do you receive from people in your social network?" The four items proved to be internally reliability (Cronbach's $\alpha = .75$).

3.2.5 | Factor analyses

We conducted confirmatory factor analyses (CFA) using EQS 6.4 for Windows (Bentler & Wu, 2018) on the items of our model variables (i.e., intergroup leadership, intergroup relational identification, resources, and psychological empowerment) taking into account the multi-dimensional nature of psychological empowerment (consisting of the four dimensions: meaning, competence, self-determination, and impact). The results of this CFA supported the distinctiveness of our constructs. Using ML Robust to correct for substantial multivariate kurtosis (Mardia's coefficient = 102.73, normalized estimate = 17.15), the CFA yielded good fit indexes ($\chi^2 = 503.79$, $df = 384$, $p < .001$, $\chi^2/df = 1.31$, NNFI = .95, CFI $z = .96$, IFI = .96; RMSEA = .038). All alternative models, including a one-factor model (i.e., Harman's single factor test, which explained <.27% of the variance; Harman, 1967) did not provide a better fit to the data.

3.2.6 | Common method bias analysis

As recommended by Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Lee, and Podsakoff (2003, p. 896), and in addition to Harman's single factor test (Harman, 1967), we used a latent variable approach to control for the effects of a single unmeasured latent factor. One of the main advantages of this technique is that it does not require that we identify and measure the specific factor responsible for the method effects; this technique models the effect of the method factor on the measures rather than on the latent constructs they represent and does not require the effects of the method factor on each measure to be equal. More specifically, using structural equation modeling (EQS 6.4; Bentler & Wu, 2018), we added a first-order factor with all items of the measures as indicators to our measurement model. When subjecting this model to confirmatory factor analysis, all factor loadings of the items on their designated constructs remained significant. Furthermore, close inspection of the factor loadings of the "common" method factor showed that 27 (out of 30) of these factor loadings were not significantly related to the common method factor, providing no substantial evidence for common method bias. Moreover, to test formally whether common method bias interfered with our measurement model (see Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Lee, & Podsakoff, 2003), we constrained all factor loadings of the common method factor to be equal (i.e., avoiding the problem of the common method factor not affecting item scores equally). Results showed that although the model fit was good ($\chi^2 = 499.80$, $df = 383$, $p < .001$, $\chi^2/df = 1.30$, NNFI = .95, CFI = .96, IFI = .96; RMSEA = .038), adding this common method factor did not significantly improve the measurement model ($\Delta\chi^2 = 3.99$, $p = ns$). We conclude from these results that the relations observed between the hypothesized constructs cannot be ascribed to common method bias, concluding that common method bias is not an issue in our data.

3.3 | Control variables

3.3.1 | Demographic variables

To control for the influence of demographic variables, we included gender (coded as male = 0/female = 1) because women tend to be more prone to relational identification than men, and men tend to be more prone to collective identification than women (Fritz & van Knippenberg, 2017), age (in years), and level of education (coded originally from the lowest to the highest level of received education, that is, 1 = elementary school to 8 = Ph.D.) as both older and higher educated employees have more intergroup contact and probably more access to resources outside the own group.

Because we build our analysis on intergroup leadership theory (Hogg et al., 2012), which positions the concept of intergroup relational identification in the concept space including team and organizational identification, we included these as control variables. This gives us the opportunity to show that the relationships that are core to our analysis really concern intergroup relational identification and do not reflect correlations with team or organizational identification.

3.3.2 | Team identification

To control for the extent to which employees identified with their team, we measured their team identification with an adaptation of the 6-item Mael and Ashforth (1992) scale with the team as referent (e.g., "When someone criticizes my team, it feels like a personal insult"; "This team's successes are my successes") (van Knippenberg & van Schie, 2000). Cronbach's α was .75 for satisfactory reliability.

3.3.3 | Organizational identification

To control for the extent to which employees identified with their organization, we measured their organizational identification with Mael and Ashforth's (1992) 6-item scale (e.g., "When someone criticizes my organization, it feels like a personal insult"; "This organization's successes are my successes"); Cronbach's α was .86 for good reliability.

4 | RESULTS

4.1 | Descriptive statistics and correlation analyses

The descriptive statistics and Pearson's correlations for the study variables are displayed in Table 1. Gender and education correlated significantly and positive with two of our model variables, showing that females experience more intergroup leadership than males ($r = .16$, $p < .05$), and the higher the level of employee education the greater their access to resources needed for performance at work ($r = .15$, $p < .05$). Older employees identified less with the

TABLE 1 Means, standard deviations, and pearson correlations for study variables

	M	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1. Gender	.28	.45								
2. Age	53.98	7.88	-.28**							
3. Education	6.29	1.52	.07	-.02						
4. Team identification	3.87	.63	.06	-.07	.17*					
5. Organizational identification	3.46	.79	-.02	-.14*	.14*	.56**				
6. Psychological empowerment	3.71	.49	.09	-.02	.01	.28**	.22**			
7. Resources	2.69	.94	.05	-.02	.15*	.08	.07	.27**		
8. Intergroup relational identification	3.49	.89	-.01	.01	.03	.38**	.25**	.19**	.28**	
9. Intergroup leadership	3.36	.96	.16*	.01	.06	.20**	.15*	.31**	.17*	.35**

Note: $N = 213$ (two-tailed significance, listwise deletion).

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$.

TABLE 2 Multiple regression results

Predictor	Model 1		Model 2		Model 3	
	Intergroup relational identification		Resources		Psychological empowerment	
	<i>b</i>	<i>SE</i>	<i>b</i>	<i>SE</i>	<i>b</i>	<i>SE</i>
Constant	.80	.58	1.31*	.66	2.37**	.33
Gender	-.13	.13	.07	.15	.04	.07
Age	.00	.01	.00	.01	.00	.00
Education	-.02	.04	.08*	.04	-.02	.02
Team identification	.45**	.11	-.10	.13	.15*	.06
Organizational identification	.04	.08	.01	.10	.06	.05
Intergroup leadership	.27**	.06	.08	.07	.12**	.03
Intergroup relational identification			.29**	.08	-.03	.04
Resources					.12**	.03
R^2/df	.23/206		.11/205		.20/204	

Note: $N = 213$ (two-tailed significance, listwise deletion).

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$.

organization ($r = -.14$, $p < .05$), and the higher the level of employee education, the more they identified with the organization ($r = .14$, $p < .05$) and with their team ($r = .17$, $p < .05$). Furthermore, the results of the correlation analysis shows that all our model variables correlated significantly and positive with each other, providing initial support for our serial mediation model.

4.2 | Hypothesis tests

To test our first hypothesis (i.e., *Intergroup leadership is positively related to psychological empowerment*), we used regression analysis to examine the relation between intergroup leadership and psychological empowerment. Results of this analysis confirmed our first hypothesis and demonstrated that intergroup leadership is positively related to psychological empowerment, $b = .16$, $SE = .03$,

$df = 211$, $p < .01$ [.0905, .2219] (gender, age, education, team identification, and organizational identification did not significantly influence the relationship of intergroup leadership and psychological empowerment).

In addition, we performed multiple regression analyses using a regression tool for mediation analysis (i.e., PROCESS Model 6; Hayes, 2012). PROCESS Model 6 “assumes a causal chain linking the variables, with a specified direction of causal flow” (Hayes, 2012, p. 14), making it possible to test the relations specified in Hypothesis 2 (i.e., *intergroup leadership positively affects psychological empowerment through intergroup relational identification and resources*). Controlled for the three demographic variables, and team identification and organizational identification, the results of this analysis showed that intergroup leadership is positively related to intergroup relational identification (see Table 2: Model 1); that intergroup relational identification is positively related to resources (Table 2: Model

2); that resources are positively related to psychological empowerment (Table 2: Model 3). In addition, regression coefficients demonstrated a positive direct relationship of intergroup leadership and psychological empowerment ($b = .12$, $SE = .03$, $[.0374, .1776]$) and a positive significant indirect relationship (95% BCa CIs, 1,000 bootstrap samples) of intergroup leadership and psychological empowerment through intergroup relational identification and resources ($b = .0093$, $Boot SE = .0041$, $[.0033, .0208]$), giving evidence of significant partial serial mediation and confirming our hypothesized model. Thus, based on these results, we confirm that intergroup leadership is positively related to employees' intergroup relational identification, which is positively related to resources, which is positively related to psychological empowerment.¹²

5 | DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

Because employee psychological empowerment depends more and more on the ability to establish collaborations across the boundaries of one's own group, the primary aim of this study was to test the relation between intergroup leadership and employee psychological empowerment. In support of our theoretical analysis, we found support for our proposed serial mediation model, in which intergroup relational identification and access to resources sequentially mediated the relationship of intergroup leadership with psychological empowerment. By showing that psychological empowerment can be enhanced by cultivating intergroup relational identification through intergroup leadership, this study shows the empowering potential of intergroup leadership and intergroup relational identity for employees who collaborate with others across group boundaries.

5.1 | Theoretical and practical implications

This study advances both empowerment theory and intergroup leadership theory. First, this paper advances empowerment theory as it demonstrates that managers have alternative ways to empower their employees besides the more traditional top down leadership empowerment behavior (e.g., Ahearne et al., 2005; Arnold et al., 2000; Kirkman & Rosen, 1999; Konczak et al., 2000). There is a clear case that psychological empowerment benefits from

collaborations with others across the boundary of one's own group. By targeting the social identity of employees that helps or hinders these cross-boundary collaborations, managers are provided with new and alternative ways to empower employees. This study adds to the growing body of empowerment research by demonstrating that the empowerment process within contemporary organizations is much more complex than thought before (Maynard, Luciano, D'Innocenzo, Mathieu, & Dean, 2014) by including intergroup leadership, and intergroup relational identification and resources as mediating explanation.

Our study has implications for intergroup leadership theory as well. A core argument in intergroup leadership theory is that intergroup relational identity is more effective in building intergroup relations than is superordinate identity (Hogg et al., 2012; Rast et al., 2018). In that respect, it is important that our findings hold when controlling for organizational identification as the most proximal superordinate identification because it provides further support for one of the core tenets of intergroup leadership theory. Since psychological empowerment is linked with a wide variety of positive outcomes like work-unit performance (Seibert et al., 2004), innovation (Spreitzer, 1995), job satisfaction (Liden et al., 2000), and organizational commitment (Avolio et al., 2004), the current evidence is also important in developing the case that intergroup leadership is advantageous to employees' effective functioning in organizations. By doing so, the present study expands the focus of intergroup leadership theory from intergroup relations per se to individuals' functioning in a context where work benefits from boundary spanning.

Interestingly and importantly, intergroup leadership theory proposes that intergroup leadership is more effective in building intergroup relational identification when the leader not only advocates such an understanding of group identity, but also engages in boundary spanning to in a sense embody the intergroup relational identity. The logic here is that by engaging in boundary spanning—reaching outside the boundaries of the own group to the other group or groups implied in the leader's conception of the group's identity—the leader functions as a role model (i.e., “walks the talk”; cf. van Ginkel & van Knippenberg, 2012). This gives greater persuasive power to the leader's advocacy of intergroup relational identity, rendering it more effective in stimulating intergroup relational identification. In intergroup leadership theory, leader boundary spanning is thus seen as a moderator of the effectiveness of leader advocacy of intergroup relational identity. A straightforward extension of the current analysis would, therefore, be to study leader boundary spanning as enhancing the influence of leader rhetoric. In the current context in which intergroup leadership is seen as important in stimulating team members to span the boundaries of the own group to gain resources from other groups, it may be especially important to the leadership effectiveness that the leader is such a boundary spanning role model. Obviously, this is for future research to determine, but this is a direction that fits well both with the current focus on psychological empowerment through gaining resources external to the own group and its basis in intergroup leadership theory.

¹²To test the robustness of our hypothesized model and to examine whether resources also act as a moderating factor, we investigated two alternatives. First, we tested a model in which relational identification, resources, and their interaction term (relational identification $\times$ resources) predicted psychological empowerment. The interaction was nonsignificant, $b = 0.03$, $SE = 0.04$, $t = 0.73$, $p = ns$. Second, we tested a moderated mediation model with intergroup leadership (X), relational identification (mediator) $\times$ resources (moderator) as predictors of psychological empowerment (Y). Also, this model was nonsignificant, $b = 0.03$, $SE = 0.04$, $t = 0.72$, $p = ns$. In sum, our post hoc analyses suggests that resources does mediate the relationship between intergroup relational identification and psychological empowerment, but does not act as a moderating factor.

²We checked whether our results were not driven by the control variables and ran our analyses also without the controls. Results of these analyses showed that the controls did not significantly change the results of our model tests. However, for theoretical and comparative reasons—which makes our study results rightfully parallel with results of other studies in this area of research—we do report them in our results section.

In addition to these theoretical implications, this research has practical implications as well, as it provides a new angle to enhance employee empowerment within organizations. This study shows that it is useful to look beyond leader empowerment behavior and to focus on the social identity processes that help or hinder the effectiveness of collaborations with others outside one's own group. Obviously, this is not to argue against the value of empowering leadership but rather to argue for a more extended leader "portfolio" of ways to build psychological empowerment. Just like other leadership behaviors, intergroup leadership should be open to leadership training and development efforts. The present findings can be seen as first evidence in favor of considering intergroup leadership as a helpful leadership competence in leadership development.

5.2 | Limitations and future research

One of the biggest possible flaws of the use of cross-sectional self-rated data is the potential presence of common method bias, threatening the validity of the conclusions about the relationships between measures. To be sure that our findings were not affected by common method bias, we controlled for the effects of a single unmeasured latent method factor (Podsakoff et al., 2003). Results of these controlling analyses demonstrated that bias inflicted by a common method factor is very unlikely in our data, confirming the reliability of our examined model and its usefulness for expanding theory on intergroup leadership and intergroup relational identification, on the one hand, and resources and psychological empowerment, on the other.

Moreover, it is important to note that the cross-sectional nature of this study excludes causal inference. Even when the causality implied in our model and our model is consistent with theory (Hogg et al., 2012) and related experimental evidence (Rast et al., 2018), future research would benefit from the use of field-experimental designs. Ideally, such an experimental design should focus on a training intervention and by doing so could also speak to the "trainability" of intergroup leadership, and therefore, bolster the confidence in our implications for practice.

Furthermore, our study looked at intergroup relational identity from the perspective of the individual employee. Effective collaboration, however, is a two-way street, and access to resources logically depends on the social identity of these collaborators. Future research might want to take a more integral approach and include the social identity of the collaborative partners. We expect that when both interaction partners form an intergroup relational identity the effectiveness of the collaboration and the exchange of resources is higher.

Finally, the items used to measure resources are formulated at a relatively high level of abstraction, which enabled employees to give an overall indication of how much of the resources needed to optimally carry out their work they received from their social network. Ideally, we would not have such a high-level measure but a measure that would more concretely assess the social network and resources

gained through network ties. Because we focused on four different resources, pragmatic concerns stood in the way of social network measures for the current study. Social network measures are taxing for respondents, in no small part because they are repetitive, and measuring a different social network for each of the resources we studied (e.g., the network of information flows) is not a realistically feasible request to respondents. Future research focusing on one specific resource (e.g., information) could, however, complement the current findings by sacrificing breadth for depth and get more concrete and specific social network data for one resource.

5.3 | Conclusion

The topic of employee psychological empowerment remains highly popular among scholars and practitioners in the field of management and organization sciences (Maynard et al., 2012; Seibert et al., 2011). This study, based on analysis of 213 responses to a survey initiated by the Dutch Ministry of the Interior and Kingdom Relations, advances our understanding of the intricacies of employee empowerment within contemporary organizations, by showing that managers have additional, alternative, and indirect ways to empower employees who regularly operate across the barriers of one's own group on top of the more traditional leader empowerment behaviors. We hope this study encourages scholars and practitioners to further explore both the concepts of intergroup leadership and intergroup relational identification, as well as the changing nature of the empowerment process. In this way, we strongly believe that it is possible to advance our understanding of employee empowerment and subsequently help contemporary organizations foster employee empowerment and increase performance.

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APPENDIX

Intergroup leadership

1. My manager makes clear that collaboration with other departments is crucial for “who we are” as a department.
2. My manager explains that the collaboration with other departments shapes our identity.
3. My manager argues that it is important to emphasize each other's unique qualities while collaborating with other departments.
4. My manager is a role model when it comes to collaboration with other departments.
5. My manager stimulates the active exchange of knowledge and resources within the department.
6. My manager discusses the interplay between internal and external collaborations with the department.
7. My manager stimulates forming and maintaining valuable collaborations.
8. My manager brings in his or her own network for the benefit of team.
9. My manager emphasizes the similarities between our own department and other departments within the Dutch Government.

Intergroup relational identification

1. The relationship between our department and other departments within the Dutch government shapes our identity.
2. The collaboration between our department and other departments within the Dutch government is part of “who we are” as a department.
3. “Who we are” as a department, is determined by the relationship with other departments within the Dutch government.
4. The relationship between our department and other departments determines who “we” are and who “they” are.
5. The relationship between our department and other departments within the Dutch government is important for the kind of government we are.